

Punctuation reference

Punctuation mark	Name	How to use
.	period	• marks the end of a complete statement • marks the end of an abbreviated word
...	ellipsis	• marks where text has been omitted or an unfinished sentence
,	comma	• follows an introductory word, phrase, or clause • can be used as parentheses, to separate a nonessential part of a sentence • can be used with a conjunction to join two main clauses • separates words or phrases in a list • represents omitted words to avoid repetition in a sentence • can be used between an introduction to speech and the direct speech
;	semicolon	• separates two main clauses that are closely related • precedes adverbs such as <i>however</i>, <i>therefore</i>, <i>consequently</i>, and <i>nevertheless</i> to connect clauses • separates items in a complex list
:	colon	• connects a main clause to a clause, phrase, or word that is an explanation of the main clause or that emphasizes a point in the main clause • introduces a list after a complete statement • introduces quoted text
'	apostrophe	• marks a missing letter • indicates possession • creates plural forms if just adding an s is confusing
-	hyphen	• links two words in compound modifiers • can be used in fractions and in numbers from twenty-one to ninety-nine • joins certain prefixes to other words
“ ”	quotation marks	• can be used before and after direct speech and quoted text • separates a word or phrase in a sentence • can be used around titles of short works
?	question mark	• marks the end of a sentence that is a question
!	exclamation point	• marks the end of a sentence that expresses strong emotion • can be used at the end of an interruption to add emphasis
()	parentheses	• can be used around nonessential information in a sentence • can be used around information that provides clarification
—	dash	• can be used in pairs around interruptions • marks a range of numbers (5–6 hours) • indicates direction of travel (Trys–Qysto route)
•	bullet point	• indicates a key point in a list
/	slash	• can be used to show an alternative instead of using the word <i>and</i> or <i>or</i>